

WYRMTONGUE



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From the Editor

WELCOME one and all, to this *Wyrmtongue* extravaganza! For those of you unfamiliar (Hi Freshers!), allow me to guide you on your journey through this binary-bound document.

We at Imperial College Sci-Fi and Fantasy Society wish to share our nerdiness with the world, and one of our methods of doing so is right before your eyes. We publish three issues of the *Wyrmtongue* every year: This introductory newsletter, an anthology of member-contributed writing and artwork and, last but not least, a magazine in honour of our annual convention.

Within these pages you will find some information on the society, introductions and book recommendations from some of our committee and more on our aforementioned annual convention, **Picocon**.

For those of you who are creatively inclined, spring term will mark the opening of our annual *Wyrmtongue* anthology submission period, where you can send in short stories, artwork and poetry to be published in another issue of *Wyrmtongue* coinciding with Picocon. As Picocon has a different theme, your work will have to be related to it. But good news! this year you will get to have a say in it (more on that in the Picocon Section below).

In the meantime, read on to learn more about the society, and if you have any questions about the anthology (or otherwise) drop a message to icsfwyrmtongue@gmail.com. Also, you are all welcome to stop by our library in **Beit's West Basement** if you want to browse our collection of books and DVDs, watch a movie, or just hang out. I look forward to seeing you there!
ΨΦ



Kiron Dutton
Editor

Captain's Log



Michael Porat

Chair Entity

GREETINGS, honoured students of Imperial College! Welcome to the Imperial College Science Fiction and Fantasy Society! I, your *uniquely humble* Chair Entity, cordially invite you to join us, whether you are a newcomer, or an experienced veteran, or anything in between!

Our glorious citadel (AKA the Sci-Fi Library) is found in the West Basement of Beit Quad. It is where we have stored our collection of over ten thousand books and three thousand DVDs, along with some beanbags and a TV to boot. You are welcome to come explore our abode whenever it is open, which is during every lunchtime throughout the week (Monday to Friday), from 12-2pm. You have full freedom on visits to peruse our collection, socialise, eat lunch, or just generally relax before an afternoon of studying.

We also host a number of events, including our regular gatherings on Friday evenings (be it for film *nights*, game *nights*, or seasonal event... *nights*). As well as this, we run subsidised cinema trips to see any of the latest sci-fi or fantasy releases. Look forward to the upcoming showing of *Clayface*, which is right around the corner! And last, but certainly not least, our annual convention Picocon, which is running for the 44th time this upcoming March!

Ultimately, with ten thousand books, I'm sure there's something for everyone in our library. Even if you're the biggest Whovian the world has ever seen, or if you've never heard of a 'Star Wars' in your life, you'll find something you'll enjoy. All you need is membership to borrow any of the books or DVDs at our disposal! And, if you're looking for something specific and we somehow don't have it, you can always submit a request for it!

So, if a tight-knit roundtable of friendly nerds suits you, come give us a visit! You can trust me, I promise this isn't a dictatorship[†]! $\Psi\Phi$

[†]Not legally binding

Welcome to the Library!

Hi! I'm Shriya, your Head Librarian for this year, and it is my honour to welcome you into our library in Beit West Basement. It is home to a vast collection of over 16,000 books and DVDs, ranging from unforgettable classics such as Lord of the Rings, to cinematic masterpieces such as Lego Batman. And better yet, our collection is ever-growing! Check out our current inventory [here](#), and if you can't find what you want, you can easily request something using this form [This Form](#), and we will add it to the library for you!

Our library is open from 12pm to 2pm every weekday, and for social events on Friday from 7pm to 10pm. Feel free to come along at these times to chill out, watch a movie, or read a book (although if you'd like to loan books, you do need to purchase society membership). I hope to see you all there! ΨΦ



Shriya Sistla
Head Librarian

Media Recommendations

If you're looking to dive into the library's collection but are having trouble deciding where to start, here are some recommendations from the committee:

Shriya Sistla

— **Nimona** by Nick Bruno & Troy Quane

One of my favourite films ever, featuring gay knights, anti-establishment messaging, and shape-shifting as a metaphor for being trans. It is beautifully animated with very fun characters, and I haven't stopped thinking about it since 2023. it also has doomed yuri!!

Lucian Brand

— **Malazan Book of the Fallen** by Steven Erikson

One of the best pieces of worldbuilding ever put to page, Erikson's series captivates the reader through his epic tale of humanity's struggles and purpose by dressing it up in a truly lived in world full of history, magic, and culture. Even the giant lizards with swords for arms get written with true respect and humanity.

Michael Porat

— **Story of Your Life and Others** by Ted Chiang

A collection of clever and touching sci-fi short stories, including the one that inspired the movie Arrival.

Sam Shenker

— **Nexus** by Yuval Noel Harari

An excellent breakdown of the history and future of communication by an author who has only written bangers. Despite not being fiction, it is simply so peak that I cannot help but recommend it. Each of his books has reshaped my worldview, and this one is especially relevant in this day and age of algorithms, AI and attention economy.

Kiron Dutton

— **Mother of Learning** by Domagoj Kurmaić

One of the best web novels out there. Explore an incredibly rich high fantasy world with our protagonist as he steadily grows, making the best of the timeloop he's found himself stuck in.

Lucian Brand

— **Jonathan Strange Mr. Norrel** by Susanna Clarke

A most strange book documenting the efforts to revive English magic during the Napoleonic wars, after the decline in England's magic since the departure of the Raven King. Despite being Clarke's first book it does not disappoint in the slightly off and wonderful style shown in Piranesi.

Shriya Sistla

— **Piranesi** by Susanna Clarke

a surreal novel with beautiful prose and a unique setting. I very much enjoyed the process of reading this book, as it slowly unravels more and more of its mysteries before culminating in a delightfully haunting ending.

Michael Porat

— **The Southern Reach Trilogy** by Jeff Vandermeer

A story exploring the mysterious, beautiful, isolated Area X (no relation to Musk). No series has given me such dread and awe as this one has.

Kiron Dutton

— **Virtuous Sons** by Y.B. Striker

Come read about the greatest bromance in the ancient (and magical) Mediterranean! While the worldbuilding is great, the characters are really what make this series shine. It's not yet complete, but the first book has been published (and is still freely available online!) and it's definitely still worth a read.

Lucian Brand

— **Supernatural** by Eric Kripke

Supernatural forms one of the key backbones of the mutilated creature that is internet fandoms. The 15-season journey of the Winchester brothers covers their exploits with everything from wendigos to God. I cannot, in good conscience, recommend beyond the first 5 seasons but it is definitely worth a watch to, if nothing else, learn some culture.

Shriya Sistla

— **Witch Hat Atelier** by Kamome Shirahama

A manga with the most intricately gorgeous illustrations, lovable characters and a

compelling story about magic. The magic system is particularly interesting, so fleshed out that the fandom continuously amazes and horrifies with the spells they create (mpreg spells, for example). It also has doomed yaoi!

Michael Porat

— **The First Law Trilogy** by Joe Abercrombie

Grimdark fantasy in a low-magic world overcome with war and realpolitik. Probably the most invested I've been in a fantasy world in a long time.

Sam Shenker

— **Nyxia** by Scott Reintgen

Although similar sounding, I did not pick this based off of the name. I read it a few years ago and it was a pretty good Enders game-like book, with enough uniqueness and intrigue that I can recommend it off its own merits. The material the book is named after is central to the book, and has a bunch of fun things that can be done with it that are fun to think and theorise about. In total, a book I thoroughly enjoyed!

Lucian Brand

— **Dungeon Crawler Carl** by Matt Dinnimann

I did this as an audiobook, which I cannot recommend enough. This series follows Carl and his cat as they navigate the 18-floor alien dungeon gameshow that used to be Earth. A very entertaining experience that you are unlikely to find elsewhere.

Kiron Dutton

— **The Mistborn Trilogy** by Brandon Sanderson

I can't speak for the sequel books, but the original Mistborn Trilogy is incredible. Brandon Sanderson is famous for his well thought out magic systems and you can tell why. It may have been a while since I read these books, but they're certainly memorable

Michael Porat

— **Y: The Last Man** by Brian K. Vaughan

Have you ever wondered what would happen if everybody on earth with a Y chromosome were to suddenly drop dead all at once, except for one incredibly corny magician and his pet monkey? No? Well, you're thinking about it now!

Lucian Brand

— **The Owl House** by Dana Terrace

It may be a children's show, but it is still one of the best pieces of media out there. Dana Terrace has created a wonderful world of witches, demons, magic, and gay, with great jokes, weird characters (especially the titular bird tube), and an interesting story - what's not to love. And with the sequel graphic novel just released, there is no better time to enter the Boiling Isles.

Michael Porat

— **The Earthsea Cycle** by Ursula Le Guin

A fantasy series where spells are cast by speaking a thing's true name. Le Guin does more with a wizard and a boat than most authors do with a whole continent, in this story about growing up and learning to accepting your mistakes.

Events



Lucian Brand

Chair of Vice
(Events Officer)

ADVOCATES of fun and misery alike are welcome to come along to our regular events throughout the year and, fortunately for those sorry souls ignorant of what we do, I am here to elucidate the murky future that is ICSF events (a future that is broadcast on our WhatsApp).

Lunchtime Openings – The society is nestled in a small and cosy library, tucked away in the bowels of Beit's West Basement. As the bastion of fiction at Imperial, our modest library's collection is growing at rate nearly beyond the valiant committee's ability to control and currently contains many thousands of books, DVDs, comics and more, with everything available for perusal and borrowing. Perhaps you wish to see the tomes, or maybe you just want a place for lunch and new friends, regardless of intention we welcome all from 12-2pm on weekdays.

Cinema Trips – At least once a term we run group outings to see new films (often at a discounted rate...). Together we can prove that cinema is not a dying art and carry out the age-old ritual of bonding over bad or, even better, great films. Our first trip this year hopes to be one of the more interesting ones to date – Clayface. DC's forays into body horror should be, if nothing else, a unique experience. Look out for the tickets!

General Events – While not a very decorated General, Regular Events hosts some interesting activities that you can visit. On Friday evenings we open the library for films, games, quizzes, or just fun. This term is a big one for special events, as we have the Halloween Party (rife with fun activities and Neil Patrick Harris) and the Christmas Party, which is preceded by a Secret Santa open to all. But if you want the truly bizarre you can come along to our termly Powerpoint Karaoke Night, where powerpoints submitted by you get presented blind. It leads to many interesting statements, and usually Hatsune Miku making an appearance. Anyone is welcome to come to these and partake, or just spectate, we don't judge.

We love to meet not just the fellow and fledgling nerds, but also the casual enjoyers. Whatever your relation to fiction, come on down and pay us a visit, you are unlikely to not find something to do and, who knows, maybe you'll even fall down the rabbit hole (we have yet to board it up). ΨΦ

Picocon

HELLO all, prospective new members and returning old ones (and any great old ones that happen to get a hold of this), and welcome to the weird written words of the Sofa! For a short introduction, Picocon is the annual convention organised and ran by our illustrious society, involving various talks from Guests of Honours and fun activities throughout a (hopefully) balmy Saturday sometime in late February.

However, this years Picocon is faced with a dastardly quandary set by this very committee... three possible topics which can (uncharacteristically democratically) be voted for during the/this welcome fair! A short(-ish) description of each option is below:

1. Utopia: The ideal society. From magical paradises to scientific post-scarcity, the high-tech optimism of Star Trek to the hidden paradise of El Dorado, the idea of Utopia has been a hopeful staple of Science Fiction and Fantasy for centuries.
2. Jargon: Ever been confused by technobabble in Star Trek, Star Wars or Stargate? Don't know your Nazgûl from your Bene Gesserit? The topic of Jargon explores how languages (both real and fictional) work, diving into detail about phrases and words only those lucky few in specific professions or cultures know.
3. Ancient Knowledge: Usually, knowledge is new. People think of things that no-one has thought of yet. What if someone had? From lost nations and dilapidated empires to the techno-magic of ancient alien civilisations, Ancient Knowledge explores them all.

The winner of these will be picked to be this years Picocon theme, so show up to our stall and vote for what you think will be the most interesting! To keep up with the going-ons and what-to-dos about Picocon, join our mailing list to get information right in your inbox! Or, just hang around the SciFi library during lunch or events - questions are always welcome, and it will probably be discussed now and then anyway.

Finally, I hope that you enjoy being at Imperial! As someone in their last year, things will be stressful and deadlines will come too fast, but it has truly been a wonderful experience. Do not be scared to put yourself out there, and take the opportunities presented to you - you won't find them anywhere else! ΨΦ



Sam Shenker

Picocon Sofa

Getting Involved

Mailing Lists

ICSF maintains the following mailing lists, to which all members are welcome to subscribe:

- `icsf-list` is the society's core mailing list, which communicates announcements of ICSF events and important news about the society. This list does not generate an overwhelming amount of traffic, and subscription is a must if you would like to hear about film trips and other activities.



Join our mailing list by scanning the QR code. Alternatively, subscribe automatically by signing up for membership at:

www.imperialcollegeunion.org/activities/a-to-z/science-fiction-and-fantasy.

Social Media

For those who welcome our social network overlords, behold continuations of the Library into the realms of cyberspace:



facebook.com/groups/ICSF.imperial

Sci-fi talk, news and events, amusing links.



[@Imperial_SciFi](https://twitter.com/Imperial_SciFi)

Sci-fi and fantasy, 280 characters at a time.



[@imperial_scifi](https://www.instagram.com/imperial_scifi)

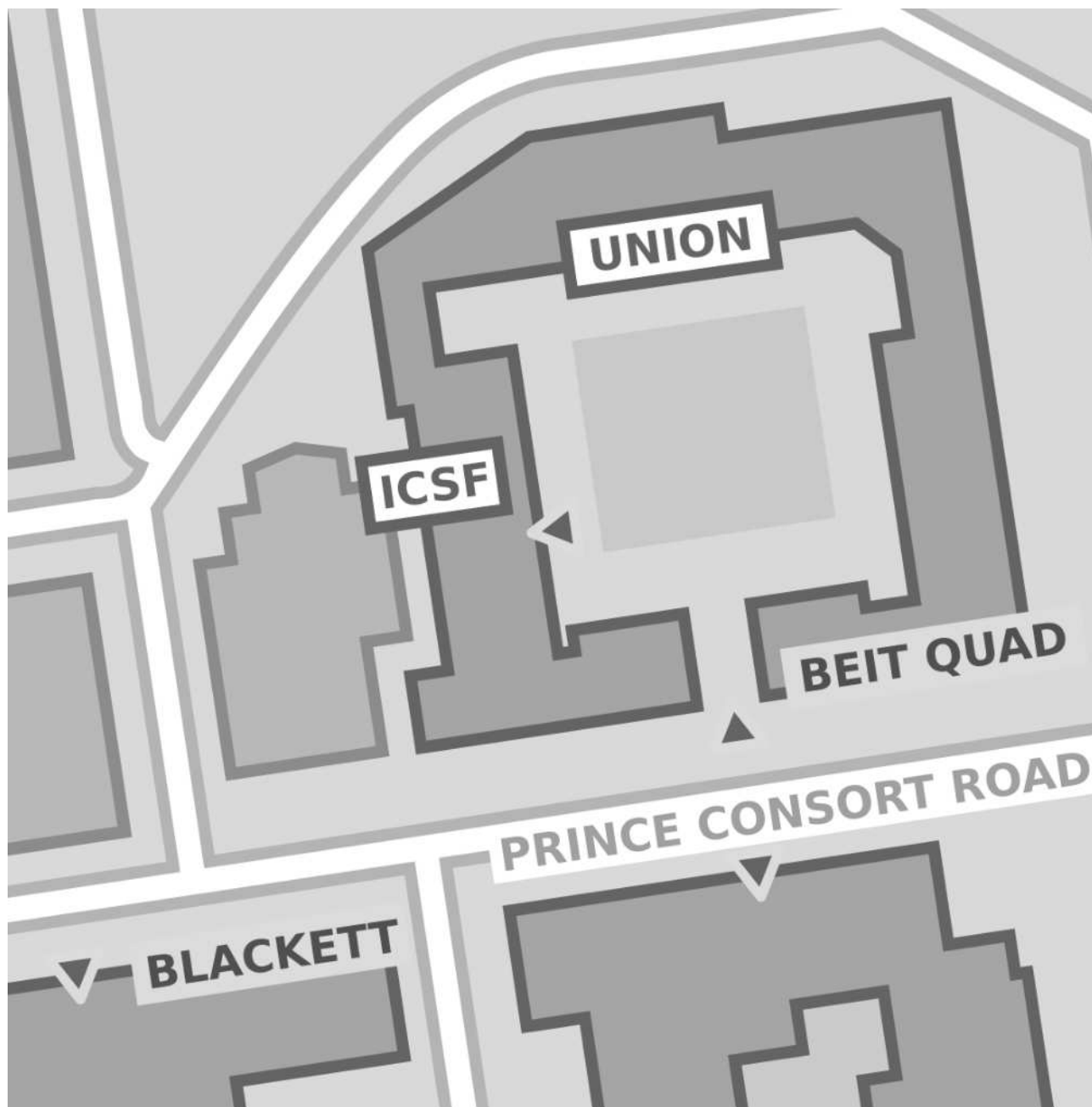
Visions from the library, visions from the future (event announcements).



linktr.ee/icsf_imperial

A library of a different kind (links).

Map to the Library



**IMPERIAL COLLEGE
SCIENCE FICTION &
FANTASY SOCIETY**

Published
September 2026
icsf.org.uk